

ChatGPT and the regression assignment

TL;DR

ChatGPT is a great tool, but if you let it do all the work, you won't learn to code - and you'll struggle later in interviews, debugging, or working on real projects. For this assignment:

- Good use → quick lookups, syntax help, error explanations, or reviewing your own working code.
- Okay but less helpful → copying small snippets you fully understand without rewriting it.
- Bad for learning → one-shot solutions or blind copy-paste (and obviously liable to getting zero if caught, in theory).

Final advice - struggle a bit first, understand what you write, and submit only what you write.

Incidentally, ChatGPT is great at writing TL;DR sections.

Using ChatGPT for this assignment - my view

For what it's worth, here is my own, hopefully realistic view on using ChatGPT for this assignment.

I don't have a moral objection to using ChatGPT - it's an incredible tool, and in real work you'd be silly not to use it when it's the best option.

But coding and analysis are skills you need to be able to *do yourself* in certain situations, and if you only ever let ChatGPT do them for you, you'll find yourself stuck when:

- You need to pass a coding interview.
- You're reviewing others' code (or ChatGPT's output) for correctness.
- You're debugging when ChatGPT's answer doesn't work.
- You're modifying a large or messy codebase.
- You need something non-standard or highly dependent on understanding business context.

- You have to verify that code is correct and fit for purpose.
- You're writing up analysis without it looking like a ChatGPT prompt dump.
- Working on codebases where ChatGPT is not available (e.g. banned due to licensing or data privacy concerns)
- High-value or ambiguous tasks where you need to be able to explain your code and decisions (see [GitHub's advice](#))

Note that I never mentioned the prac test, because it's just an artificial hurdle.

For this assignment, your goals are:

1. **Get good marks.**
2. **Learn to write R code yourself.**

If you just prompt ChatGPT for the whole memo or for one-shot code, you'll likely achieve #1 but sacrifice #2. That's fine for *this* deadline (unless you are caught, of course), but then you will have to learn later.

Use cases

Moving on, here's how I think you can use ChatGPT effectively whilst promoting learning in this assignment:

Good use cases (like a faster Google):

- Looking up function names or syntax you've forgotten (e.g. the arguments for `hist()`).
- Getting reminders of base R plotting functions.
- Asking for explanations of error messages you don't understand.

Another good use case, but one only to do once your code is fully working:

- Getting ChatGPT to review your *own* working code and suggest improvements - you'll pick up useful tricks.

Acceptable but less helpful (use sparingly):

- Copying *small* snippets if you fully understand them. Preferably rewrite what you find, rather than copy-pasting.

Unhelpful for learning:

- Asking for and submitting a one-shot solution or memo.
- Blindly copying and pasting blocks of code you haven't read or tested.

General advice for this assignment

- **Struggle a bit first.** Don't spend two hours stuck, but do try to work through problems before asking for help from ChatGPT. Read the help files, inspect error messages, and test variations. Do this enough, and your debugging skills will eventually become dramatically better. It's really just practice, coding is not rocket science.
- **Be honest.** Submit your own work, even if it's messy - the goal is to build a foundation you can improve next year.

Bottom line:

Learn to code by writing code, so that you can be a competent coder in the future. Don't let ChatGPT short-circuit your learning by letting it do all the work for you, unless you feel you can prompt your way through real work later.